WISCONSIN

The Badger State



In the 1840s, Danish immigrants began arriving on the western shore of Lake Michigan and settling in a town called Racine, Wisconsin—a place of raw lumber, muddy streets, and remarkable promise. They had crossed the Atlantic seeking work, land, and the particular freedom that comes from starting over. What they carried with them, tucked alongside their tools and their language, was something far more delicious—a baking tradition stretching back centuries through the bakeries and farmhouse kitchens of Denmark.

Among the earliest of these settlers were families who had worked as bakers and craftsmen in Copenhagen and the Danish countryside. They brought with them the art of wienerbrød—a laminated, buttery pastry dough folded dozens of times by hand to create tissue-thin layers that shattered at the touch and melted almost before they could be tasted. In Denmark, this technique had been introduced in the mid-1800s by Austrian bakers, refined by Danish hands, and elevated into something the Danes made entirely their own. The oval-shaped Kringle—filled with almond paste, pecans, or fruit, glazed and tender—was the crown jewel of that tradition.

Racine's Danish community grew steadily through the latter half of the 19th century, clustering in neighborhoods where the Danish language was spoken on the street and the smell of butter and cardamom drifted from kitchen windows on cold mornings. Danish bakeries began appearing along Main Street and Monument Square, their windows fogged with warmth against Wisconsin winters that must have felt, at least in temperature, something like home. The bakers of Racine took the Kringle seriously—apprentices trained for years to master the folding technique, learning to coax the dough into its signature pretzel-like oval shape before filling, glazing, and baking it to a perfect pale gold.

By the mid-20th century, Kringle had become so deeply embedded in Racine's identity that the city earned a reputation extending well beyond Wisconsin's borders. Families ordered them shipped across the country. Local bakeries—O&H Danish Bakery, founded in 1949, among the most celebrated—became institutions, their recipes guarded and their craft unchanged across generations. In 2013, the state of Wisconsin made it official, naming Kringle the State Pastry, a recognition that felt less like an honor than a simple acknowledgment of what anyone who had ever spent a morning in Racine already knew.

What those Danish settlers built in Wisconsin was more than a community—it was a table worth sitting at. And at the center of that table, flaky and fragrant and impossibly tender, was always the Kringle. Once you pull your own from the oven and drizzle it with icing, filling your kitchen with the scent of butter and almond, you will understand completely why an entire city never let it go.

SERVING SUGGESTION

Kringle is perfect for breakfast, brunch, or dessert. Pair with a cup of strong coffee or a glass of cold milk for an authentic Wisconsin experience.

KRINGLE

Every layer of dough is a quiet act of love, folded in for whoever gathers at your table.

Yield: 1 large kringle

INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 2 cups all-purpose flour
- 2 Tbsp granulated sugar
- ½ tsp salt
- ½ packet (1⅛ tsp) active dry yeast
- ½ cup warm milk (110°F / 43°C)
- 1 large egg
- ¼ cup unsalted butter, softened

BUTTER LAYER

- ½ cup cold unsalted butter
- 1 Tbsp all-purpose flour

FILLING

- ½ cup unsalted butter, softened
- 6 Tbsp packed brown sugar
- ¼ cup almond paste, crumbled
- ½ cup pecans, finely chopped
- ½ tsp vanilla extract

GLAZE

- ½ cup powdered sugar
- 1 Tbsp whole milk
- ¼ tsp vanilla extract

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Prepare the dough*: In a large bowl, whisk together the flour, sugar, salt, and yeast. Add the warm milk, egg, and softened butter, and stir until a soft, shaggy dough forms. Turn it out and knead just until smooth, about 3–4 minutes. The dough should be soft but not sticky. Shape it into a rough rectangle, wrap, and chill for 1 hour. A well-chilled dough is what lets the butter layers stay distinct instead of melting in.
2. *Make the butter layer*: While the dough chills, place the stick of cold butter and the 1 Tbsp flour between two sheets of parchment. Pound and roll them together into a flat rectangle about 5 by 7 inches. Keep it cold—if it softens, chill it again before using. This solid, pliable sheet of butter is the heart of the flaky layers to come.
3. *Laminate the dough*: On a lightly floured surface, roll the chilled dough into a rectangle about 8 by 14 inches. Lay the butter rectangle over the bottom two-thirds, then fold the bare third down over the middle and the buttered bottom third up over that, like folding a letter. Give the dough a quarter turn, roll it back out to a long rectangle, and fold in thirds again. Wrap and chill 30 minutes. Repeat this roll-and-fold twice more, chilling 30 minutes between each turn. These repeated folds build the dozens of thin layers that make a kringle flaky. Chill a final 1 hour, or overnight.

4. *Make the filling*: In a bowl, beat together the softened butter, brown sugar, almond paste, chopped pecans, and vanilla until it forms a spreadable paste. Set aside.
5. *Shape the kringle*: On a floured surface, roll the laminated dough into a long strip about 6 by 24 inches. Spread the filling down the center of the strip, then fold the long sides in over the filling to overlap, sealing the seam. Turn the seam-side down and gently shape into a large flat oval, tucking one end into the other to form a closed ring. Transfer to a parchment-lined baking sheet and flatten gently with your hands—a kringle should be wide and flat, not tall.
6. *Proof*: Cover the shaped kringle loosely and let it rise in a warm spot until puffy, about 45 minutes to 1 hour. It won't double, but it should look noticeably plumped.
7. *Bake*: Adjust the oven rack to the middle position and preheat to 375°F (190°C). Bake the kringle for 25–30 minutes, until deep golden brown and flaky throughout. If it browns too fast, tent loosely with foil for the last few minutes. Let cool on the pan for 10 minutes, then transfer to a wire rack to cool completely.
8. *Ice and serve*: Whisk together the powdered sugar, milk, and vanilla into a smooth, pourable icing. Add a little more milk if needed. Drizzle it over the cooled kringle in thin ribbons. Let the icing set for a few minutes before slicing crosswise to serve.

